NEVER TOO MUCH

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I WAS ABOUT FIVE YEARS OLD when it happened. I don't recall who it was, but somebody in my family said something that hurt my feelings. I don't remember what they said. And I don't know if it was even particularly hurtful. But I do remember crying. I cried a lot when I was a boy. Too much, I was told.

I was different, I was told. I was "too sensitive," an observation that felt like both a judgment and a reprimand. Too sensitive. These were words that carried suspicion and wariness. Too sensitive. These words are among my earliest memories. They have haunted me ever since.

As a young child, I was quiet. Like my mother, I was a reader. I didn't want to run around outside as much as my brothers, and I had not yet been bitten by the basketball bug that hit most of my neighborhood. Instead, I wanted to stay in the house or sit on the steps, losing myself in the books my mother brought home from work. These were not, I would learn, suitable choices for a Black boy, particularly one growing up in North Philadelphia.

This isn't one of those gently anti-Black stories about anti-intellectualism or homophobia in my community. As Americans, we were as susceptible as anyone else to those elements. But not exceptionally so. We were human, not pathological. Something else was happening.

I was loved. Deeply. But we lived in a world framed by suffocating ideas about who a person—who a Black person, who a Black man—needed to be in order to be safe and happy. This world held few safe spaces for little Black boys who moved through the world in the ways I was naturally inclined to move. So I learned to move differently. I learned not to cry.

I learned that my humanity was bound up in my masculinity. I was taught that my masculinity was best shown through physical strength and paying bills and controlling space and being emotionally lean.

And although we don't want to admit it, there was a functionality to this type of masculinity. As unhealthy as our performances were, looking tough and acting "hard" meant that people would be less likely to test us. Looking like we could fight meant that we wouldn't have to fight. And most of the time, deep down, we didn't want to fight.

We just wanted to live. We just wanted to be loved well. We wanted to be seen. We wanted to be respected. We wanted to be human.

My model for manhood came from my father. He held our family close and led us through storms, including the ones created by his own unhealthy masculinity. Although he was an educated man, he loved to work with his hands. He spent most of his free time fixing the broken-down rental properties he owned. The repairs, the painting, the roofing, he did it all himself. I would run behind him on the way to whatever property he was fixing. He would call out from the front of the car, "Put that book down. Look at that building they're putting up over there!" Part of that was, I'm sure, teaching me to be more social and observant. The other part, I think, was about balancing me out, pulling me away from the boy who sat on stoops and read Judy Blume while other children ran around.

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Like most men of his generation, my father showed little emotion and no vulnerability. And what other examples were there? Pop culture gave us *The Cosby Show,* but the Huxtable world of expensive art and famous friends was too foreign to seem real. And the other shows—*Diff'rent Strokes, What's Happening!!*—didn't have present Black fathers. *Good Times* gave us James Evans, Sr., until he died in a car accident in Mississippi. But when he was present, James was the personification of traditional masculinity. He loved and provided for his family. He showed no vulnerability, no tears. James's emotional expression lived in two spheres: sensual desire for his wife and anger at some disruption or injustice.

Lust and rage have always been hallmarks of American manhood. And they're supported by the assertion they are representative, too, of a certain kind of logic. They make sense. They're reasonable. They're certainly not womanish, which is limited to crying or hysteria. ("Hysteria" comes from the Greek, meaning "womb"—where life is formed.) We have decried and diminished women for how they express their feelings, how they expose their vulnerability. At the same time, we yell and scream and punch walls, all while complaining that women are "too emotional." We fail to see that our expressions of masculine rage are, in fact, emotions. And in our rage, we are never told that we are too sensitive or too emotional. As long as our only legible emotion is anger, we are never shamed.

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These are the rules that I learned and spent most of my early life following. Religiously.

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HERE'S WHAT I WAS *not* taught.

Black men model manhood after those who oppress us. We measure our humanity against the humanity of those who seek to kill us, our families, and maybe most of the planet. We imagine freedom to be the ability to accumulate the kind of unchecked power and privilege of cisgendered heterosexual White men. We eagerly embrace the toxicities of this conception of manhood: hypermasculinity, hypersexuality, homophobia, misogyny, and violence. Anytime we deviate from this script, we feel less masculine. And when we feel less masculine, we feel less human.

We swallow poison.

We embrace preachers whose theologies subordinate women and dehumanize Queer congregants. We venerate coaches who scream at us. We bond over fraternity rituals that require us to beat one another into brotherhood. We romanticize rage and the violence that accompanies it. Too often, our humanity is tied to our harm, our oppression.

Like the invented category of Whiteness, masculinity is an inherently corrupt idea. In the same way that I don't want to recover or recuperate Whiteness, or reform or rebuild the police, I don't want to recuperate masculinity. Instead, it must be destroyed, along with all other frameworks that prevent the full expression of joy, freedom, safety, self-determination, and dignity. And for Black men, the stakes couldn't be higher.

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IT'S JUNE 2020 AND America is on its heels. Not just because of COVID-19, but because young people have taken to the streets to resist state violence. I was asked to Zoom into *Drink Champs,* a podcast hosted by rapper N.O.R.E., to discuss racism, policing, and other social issues. I was joining N.O.R.E. along with rappers and activists Talib Kweli, Bun B, and Mysonne. About two hours into the panel, an unexpected guest popped in.

Russell Simmons.

I was stunned.

Even before the accusations emerged about him, women friends I knew and loved told me that he had sexually assaulted them. It had been a common story in the New York media world that I'd come up in.

My blood boiled. Had I known that Russell was going to be invited, I would have immediately turned down or canceled the appearance. I texted N.O.R.E. to express my frustration and tell him that I needed to leave. He wasn't checking his phone.

Nervous, I texted a friend for advice. What do I do? She told me to stay but be careful not to affirm Russell in any way. I did my best to avoid any contact with him or even acknowledge his existence. Although it felt like an eternity, Russell left almost as quickly as he'd appeared. After the show, the host apologized for not telling me about the surprise appearance.

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In the moment, I felt that I had done the best I could under unexpected circumstances. In reality, there were two options I did not exercise: speaking out right then or immediately leaving the show. Instead, I allowed my desire to be "professional" to stop me from going off script or leaving without notifying the host. And this is the ultimate embodiment of male privilege. As a man, I had the luxury of not having to make better, more responsible choices because I am considerably less likely to be harmed in the same ways as his alleged victims.

If a White supremacist had been on the show, I wouldn't have stayed. I would have voiced my opposition and swiftly removed myself.

Did I worry that speaking out against a man who had harmed Black women would make me professionally vulnerable? Would I have to relinquish some false sense of manhood? What is the cost of silence in the face of sexual violence against members of our community, against women, Queer folk?

At these moments, I realize that I have not come nearly as far as I would like to convince myself that I have.

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AS AN UNDERGRADUATE AT Temple University, I was taking an unreasonable number of courses. I was committed to graduating that fall, but I needed to find one more class that fit my schedule. After checking the offerings from the African American studies department, I found the perfect option: a course called "The Black Woman." I didn't really have a sense of what it was about, but what did I have to lose? At the very least, I figured, there would be a lot of women in the class. And I was right. I walked into a room of brilliant and beautiful Black women and only one other brother.

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The course was taught by Dr. Renoir McDonaugh, a Black feminist psychologist. We read scholarly texts like *Critical Race Feminism* and *Black Feminist Thought,* as well as novels like *Their Eyes Were Watching God*. The class radically shifted nearly everything that I thought I knew about myself, my sense of manhood. The work of bell hooks and Patricia Hill Collins helped me rethink my relationship to myself, my body, and the women in my life. For the first time, I learned to decenter myself and other male perspectives. I was unsettled in the best possible way.

I realized I was using my body in ways that weren't healthy for me. My choices weren't bringing me joy. In some ways, they were reinforcing my pain, the separation of mind and body. I was becoming emotionally void. I started reflecting on my relationships. I started to release the idea of healing through unhealthy means.

Sometimes men start punching things because we want to cry. We smoke, we drink, we have a lot of sex because we can't locate any functional alternatives. Growing up, I had to find "boy" things to do in order to feel like I was a whole person. It started as basketball, and then, as I got older, it was sex. I knew no other ways. What if there was something else?

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Possibilities began to unfold about not only a different world, but a different me in that world. Exploring these possibilities made me feel both better and worse. Who had I been and who could I be? I started to feel vulnerable. Instead of running from that feeling, I doubled down and started going to therapy.

Today, therapy is a staple of my emotional diet, and I'm so much better for it. In the beginning, I saw it as a badge of shame, a sign of spiritual and psychological failure. Now it's a vital form of health maintenance. It's key to my survival.

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IN ORDER TO UNLEARN unhealthy masculinity, we must run toward our fears. We must be willing to embrace the various forms of vulnerability that emerge when we disrupt the status quo. In my life, I've come face-to-face with the growing pains that accompany social, emotional, and professional vulnerability.

Professional vulnerability asks: *What jobs are you willing to lose?* Social vulnerability asks: *What networks and friendships are you willing to lose?* Emotional vulnerability asks: *Which layers of masculinity am I willing to shed in order to be a better—or really a whole—person?*

As a progressive man and someone who identifies as a feminist, I have done my absolute best to unlearn the unhealthiest parts of my identity. Through therapy, deep study, and engaged listening, I've unlearned the habit of restricting my emotions. At the same time, I have learned that I am allowed to be vulnerable, to be sad and in pain. I have come to think not individually but collectively, in community. This meant that I had to be accountable to people, as well as hold people accountable.

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Accountability requires that I resist unhealthy masculinity in real time as it takes up space. For example, in academic meetings where everyone has a doctoral degree, my female colleagues are disproportionately asked to take notes. My job is to disrupt that practice by pointing it out, as well as making sure that I or another male colleague takes the notes. Romantically, it's making sure that my partner isn't doing all the traditional domestic work. Socially, it's speaking out against homophobia, hypermasculinity, and patriarchy in moments when it's so much easier to just be silent. It's creating space for my gay, lesbian, bisexual, transgender, and Queer sibs. I had to acknowledge that there are other ways to perform gender and masculinity. I had to unlearn traditional gender roles.

It's not enough for me to just not be homophobic. I cannot be friends with homophobes. I have to actually be willing to divest myself from relationships that are unhealthy. We all do.

When we're hanging in the locker room and somebody says something homophobic or when we are in the frat house and somebody says something misogynistic, we must be willing to speak up, even though there will be no social reward. And when the pushback comes, that's when we have to be willing to be strong. The people we're defending and the lives that we're affirming are more important than our social comfort. We have to be willing to detach ourselves from it.

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It's easy for me to proclaim these values publicly, on a television broadcast or social media. I get all the benefits of being progressive when the world is watching. When no one is watching is when we are truly being tested.

Emotional vulnerability can cut deep. The world hasn't created space for us, particularly Black men, to say, "What you said hurt my feelings" or "What you said made me feel insecure or inadequate." "I miss you." "I love you."

These are things that we're not allowed to do. All of our emotionality has to come through the lens of those hypermasculine traits like anger, violence, and sexuality. Sending a *wyd* text at 2:00 A.M. and saying "I miss you" are two totally different things.

Not believing that I had the space to be emotionally vulnerable is its own kind of pain. It kept me boxed in and prevented me from exercising the full range of who I am. It totally undermined my relationships.

In my twenties, dating was very difficult. I wasn't able to express what I was feeling. So I remained silent or distant. I dated a woman who often said, "You're not a connector." I didn't know what she meant at the time, but I've realized that because I wasn't able to connect, it made it much harder for her to feel safe, happy, and loved in the relationship. My emotional rigidity made it hard for me to love her well.

But when we're not emotionally vulnerable, we miss out on opportunities to have more authentic human relationships. It's harder to draw closer to our children. It's harder to draw closer to our parents. It's harder to draw closer to our romantic partners and friends. We never actually tap into the things that are bothering us or we're struggling with, because we can't acknowledge that we're hurt. We convince ourselves that we're feeling something different.

But it doesn't have to stay this way. We don't have to lose pieces of ourselves. We don't have to lose pieces of life.

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I OFTEN REFLECT ON who I was as a little boy, before I internalized the belief that my sensitivity and vulnerability were legitimate sources of shame. Back then, I instinctively knew to follow my joy and be present in my feelings. I knew to honor what I felt, and I knew that I felt a lot. I knew that I was never too much. That what I felt wasn't too much. I'm trying to know that again.

I imagine a world where everyone has the kind of space they need to know their joy. A world where they can safely share their hearts. A world where their emotional needs can be met. And my freedom dreams are tied up with the project of dismantling any vision of manhood that limits or shames us. As long as we are not living in our full humanity, we cannot create a world for humanity.

The key to achieving this world is found in the practice. Having "good politics" matters, but so does our collective and daily labor. If we want more Black men to be vulnerable, we have to continue to show them how. We have to normalize telling people we love them and showing the men in our lives affection. If we want to produce newer and healthier forms of masculinity, those of us with platforms, power, and access have to continue to model it.

At forty-two, I'm watching a generation of people after me work to figure this all out. I want them to have corrected the mistakes my generation made and create new spaces for learning. It's happening. I'm beginning to see wider representations of masculinity, manhood, and emotionality.

As for me, I'm still, and forever, in process. I continue to see so many contradictions and places where I fall short. I don't see myself as an exemplar. I'm just somebody who's trying his best to figure this world out, failing every day but still committed to getting better.

A few weeks before writing this, I was doing a podcast talking about the tragic death of Kobe Bryant, whom I knew since childhood. In midsentence, as I reflected on the pain that came with the sudden loss, I started to cry. I couldn't have felt more vulnerable. But more important, I was completely okay sitting in that vulnerability.

Despite my considerable failures and contradictions, moments like this remind me that I'm growing and learning. Decades after being told I was too sensitive, I've never been more emotionally expressive or transparent. I've never felt more available to the people I love. I've never felt more healthy. I've never felt more free.